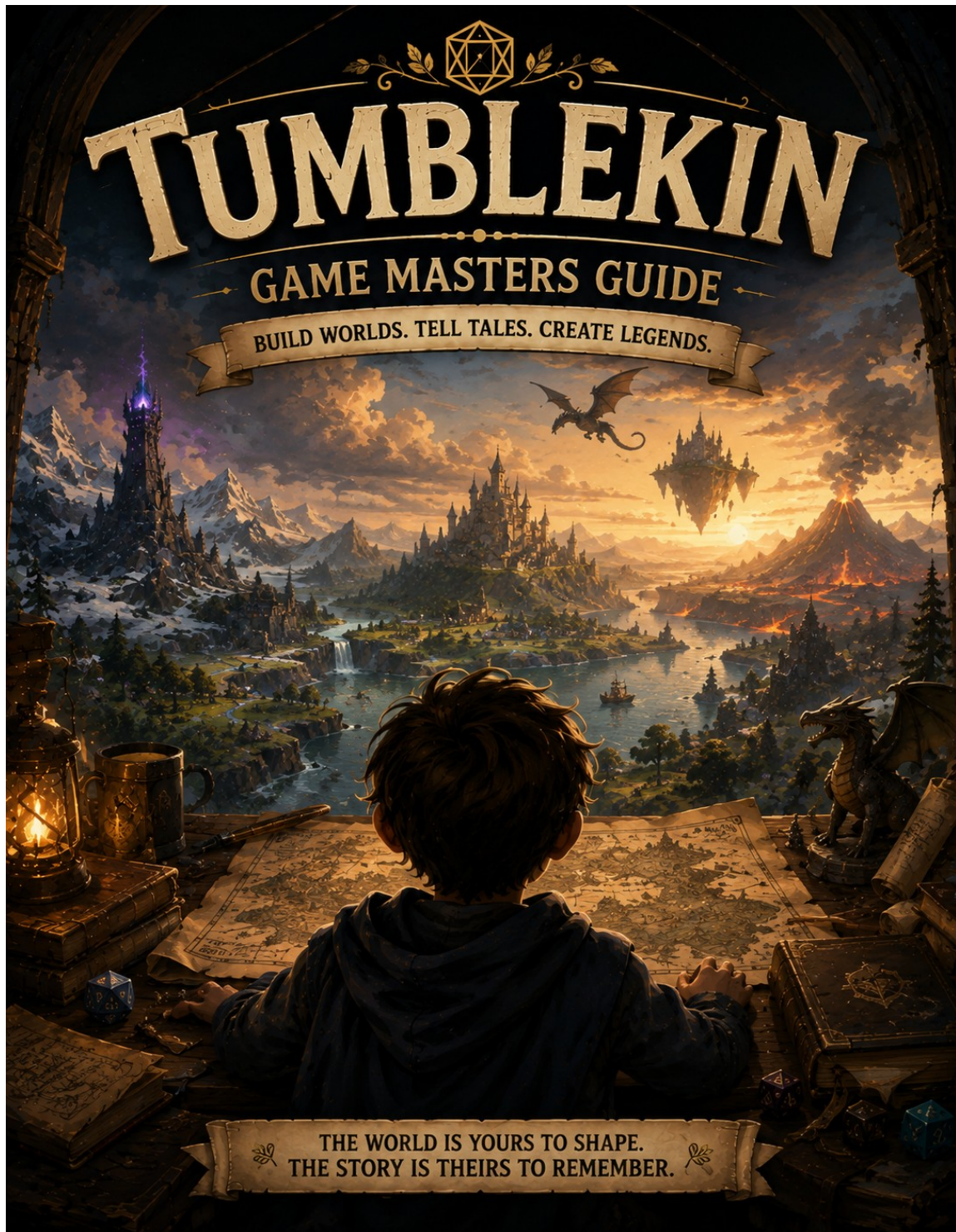


Tumblekin: Game Master's Guide

A simple guide to creating worlds, running adventures, and becoming the Game Master.



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WELCOME, GAME MASTER!

Every great adventure needs someone to bring the world to life.

That's You!

The **Game Master**, or **GM**, describes the world, plays the characters and monsters that the heroes meet, creates challenges, and ultimately decides what happens when the heroes try something unexpected.

Being the GM might sound like a big job, and it is, but don't worry. You don't need to know everything, you don't have to memorize every rule, You don't need to have every possibility planned out, and you definitely don't need to know what the heroes have planned to do next.

Your job is simply to describe the world, listen to what the heroes want to do, and decide what happens next, When you aren't sure. **Roll the dice** and find out!

WHAT DOES THE GM DO?

During an adventure, the GM has a few important jobs.

Describe the world: Tell the players what their heroes can see, hear, smell, and experience in the environment surrounding them. Instead of simply saying "You enter a dungeon room." you might say "The old stone door creaks open. Inside is a cold, dark chamber covered in cobwebs. Across the room you can see a treasure chest, next to it is a giant rat!"

You don't need enormously long descriptions, just make sure you're including enough details to imagine the scene as you see it, then ask "**What do you do?**"

Play everyone else: The players control their heroes, but you control everyone else. Kings, villagers, merchants, goblins, talking items, and every other creature the heroes encounter are all played by the GM.

You don't need to be a great actor, or be good at funny voices. Simply think about what that character wants and how they interact with the heroes.

Create challenges: Heroes need problems to solve. A fallen tree might block the road, a goblin might steal their backpack, a mysterious door might refuse to open, or maybe a huge dragon might be sleeping on top of the treasure they need.

Not every challenge needs to result in a fight. You can come up with puzzles and riddles, require the heroes to sneak, or investigate, climb, trick someone, or even hide. Ridiculous ideas are the best part of the adventure.

Make the decisions: Tumblekin cannot have a rule for everything a hero might try. That is intentional.

When something unexpected happens, the GM decides how the world responds. Be fair and keep the adventure moving. Don't worry about finding the perfect answer.

THE GM'S MOST IMPORTANT QUESTION

As the GM there is one question you'll be asking the heroes more than anything else.

“What do you do?”

Try not to tell the players how they should solve a problem, instead describe the situation and let them decide. Imagine the heroes discover a locked castle door. Don't immediately say *“Make an agility check to pick the lock.”* Instead you can say *“The castle door is locked, what do you do?”* Maybe they try and pick the lock, maybe the warrior tries to burst through it, or maybe a wizard sends their magic hand through a window to unlock it. Maybe they simply knock and wait for an answer, and sometimes they might think of something that you never even imagined.

That, is the fun of Tumblekin!

WHEN SHOULD YOU ROLL?

Heroes don't need to roll for everything. If something is easy, reasonable, or there isn't much of a chance for failure, simply let it happen. A hero doesn't need to make a might check to open a normal door, they probably don't need an agility check to climb a ladder.

Climbing up the castle wall during a storm though, that might require a roll.

Ask for a difficulty check whenever:

- The outcome is uncertain.
- Failure would matter.
- The task is difficult or dangerous.
- Rolling would make the situation more exciting.

If none of these are true, you probably don't need a roll.

Choosing a difficulty:

When a difficulty check is needed, choose a DC.

DIFFICULTY	DC
Easy	8
Normal	10
Tricky	12
Hard	15
Very Hard	18

Don't spend too much time picking a DC. Ask yourself *“How difficult does this seem?”* Then choose the closest DC. Difficulty should describe the task, not the hero attempting it.

A heavy stone door doesn't become heavier because the warrior attempts to open it instead of the rogue.

Choosing the right stat:

When asking for a DC, choose whichever stat best represents what the hero is doing.

STAT	AFFECTS
Might	Strength, Toughness, Physical power.
Agility	Speed, Balance, Accuracy, Sneakiness.
Mind	Knowledge, Investigation, Cleverness, Magical skill.
Heart	Courage, Kindness, Personality, Empathy.

Sometimes more than one stat can make sense, that's okay!

A hero trying to get past a guard might use ***Heart*** to convince them. Another hero might use ***Mind*** to create a believable story. Listen to what the player is actually trying to do and choose the stat that makes the most sense to you.

USING TRAINING

Heroes choose three things they are trained in during character creation. When a training clearly helps with what the hero is trying to do, they add +2 to their DC roll.

Don't make players fight for their training bonuses, if it reasonably applies, let them use it.

You can also allow players to create their own unique trainings. If it fits the hero and everyone agrees, it can be a training.

ADVANTAGE AND DISADVANTAGE

Advantage and disadvantage are useful GM tools and should be used as such.

Give ***Advantage*** when something makes success considerably easier. This might happen because another hero is helping with the task, the hero has the perfect tool, someone created a clever plan, or the situation strongly favors the hero.

Give ***Disadvantage*** when circumstances make something considerably harder. This might happen because the hero can't see, the floor is slippery, they're badly outnumbered, or something is interfering with them.

SAY YES TO CREATIVE IDEAS

Players will eventually attempt something you never expected, That's good! You don't need a written rule to allow something. Simply ask yourself "*Could this actually work?*" if the answer is yes, let them try! If success isn't certain, ask for a difficulty check and let the dice decide. Remember to use Advantage and Disadvantage when it makes sense to do so.

FAILURE SHOULD DO SOMETHING

Failing a roll doesn't necessarily mean that nothing happens, Maybe it just alters the situation. If a hero fails to climb a wall, maybe instead of not climbing at all they begin to scale the wall but slip and fall catching themselves on a banner. That way, the hero still gets to make some progress towards their goal but not as much as they had initially hoped.

Failures create new problems, new problems create adventure, and adventure fuels the game.

RUNNING BATTLES

When a battle scene begins, everyone first rolls for initiative. This just figures out the fighting order of all heroes and monsters. Heroes roll **1d20 + Agility**, and Monsters simply roll **1d20**. Arrange everyone from highest to lowest score and that is your fighting order.

On their turns each hero and monster can make **One Action and One Move**. The GM controls the monsters and decides what they do on their turns. Monsters should behave in ways that make sense, and both heroes and monsters should move distances that make sense.

Monsters don't always have to fight until their HP reaches 0, they may sometimes surrender, retreat, escape, negotiate, or even change sides.

BUILDING ENCOUNTERS

There is no exact method for creating the perfect encounters. Instead think about how dangerous you want the encounter to feel.

An **Easy** encounter should give the heroes a clear advantage, contain a small number of weak enemies, and are good for introducing combat and making the heroes feel powerful.

A **Normal** encounter should have the heroes and monsters reasonably matched. The heroes should probably still win, but will need to fight intelligently.

A **Hard** encounter should lean in favor of the monsters through numbers, strength, or environment. Heroes may need teamwork, clever ideas, or resources to succeed.

A **Big Bad** encounter is an important and dangerous enemy. They usually have more HP than normal monsters and at least one memorable special ability. Big Bad's can be especially fun when they have a weakness that the heroes can discover and use against them.

Start small when you're unsure how difficult a battle should be. You can always introduce more monsters later.

CREATING MONSTERS

Creating a monster in Tumblekin is easy! Every monster needs the following:

- HP – How much damage it can take.
- AC – How difficult it is to hit.
- ATK – The bonus added to its attack roll.
- DMG – The damage it deals when it hits.

It can also have a special ability, but not all monsters need to have them. You can find some sample monsters listed in the “Adventurer’s Guide”, or in the soon-to-come “Monsters Compendium.”

Special abilities do not need to have complicated rules, they should usually just be one short sentence that gives the monster something interesting it can do.

If you’re unsure of how strong a monster should be, just remember, it’s better to have a weak enemy that you can add more of later than a super strong enemy that wipes out the heroes and cuts the adventure short. You can always make the next monster stronger.

RUNNING NPCs

An *NPC*, or ***Non-Player Character*** is any character controlled by the GM that is not a monster. Most NPCs don’t even need stats. A shopkeeper probably doesn’t need HP, AC, Might, Agility, Mind, or Heart. You just need to know who they are, what they want, and how they act. If an NPC becomes important you can always assign them stats later.

CREATING TREASURE

Treasure doesn’t always have to make heroes stronger. It can simply be interesting, heroes might find coins, gems, potions, keys, important letters, or ridiculous objects. When creating treasures with abilities try and give them interesting abilities rather than enormous bonuses.

HERO TOKENS

Every hero receives one hero token per adventure. Remember that the token isn’t just for re-rolls, a player can also add a small helpful detail to the scene. When deciding whether to allow their idea ask yourself “*Does it help without completely solving the problem?*” If the answer is yes, allow it.

YOU CAN CHANGE THINGS

You’re the Game Master, if something isn’t working, change it. If a battle is taking too long, a monster might surrender or run away. If the heroes are struggling they might find something helpful. If everyone is fascinated by an unimportant NPC you created, make them important. If you forget a rule, make a reasonable decision and continue playing, you can check the rule later. Keeping everyone engaged is more important than stopping to check for the perfect answer.

THE SECRET TO BECOMING A GOOD GM

You don't need incredible voices.

You don't need hundreds of pages of notes.

You don't need expensive miniatures.

You don't need to know every rule.

You don't even need to know exactly how the adventure will end.

Listen to your players.

Give their heroes interesting problems.

Let their decisions matter.

Celebrate their clever ideas.

Make failure interesting.

And when everyone looks at you after doing something completely ridiculous that you never expected...

Smile...

Think about what would happen...

And say

“ROLL THE DICE”

note from the author

Thank you!

Every great story needs an author, and in your games that author is you. Without players such as yourself stepping up to the plate for the role of GM games like Tumblekin and others would not be possible.